



FREE RESOURCE FOR SCHOOL TEAMS

School FA Starter Kit



Five functional analysis formats for schools: step-by-step task analyses, printable datasheets, and graphing pages.

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Companion to the CalABA webinar, Oct 9, 2026

Functional Behavior Assessment in a School Setting
CalABA - Behavior Analysts in Education SIG (BAE)

behaviorschool.com

Why I wrote this kit

I'm a school-based board certified behavior analyst (BCBA), and I'm strongly pro-FBA. This kit is the take-home companion to the CalABA - Behavior Analysts in Education SIG (BAE) presentation, Functional Behavior Assessment in a School Setting.

Assess, don't guess.

FBA is the broader assessment process; experimental FA is one tool within it. Use the least risky assessment that can answer the question well enough to guide an effective plan. When function remains uncertain, especially with serious behavior, consider an individualized FA conducted by competent staff with a documented safety plan. Then verify the plan through measured outcomes.

When an FBA becomes a 10-page guess

A record review, interview, rating scale, and ABC observation can help build a hypothesis. The assessment adds value when its evidence guides the plan and the team measures whether that plan works. If important uncertainty remains, choose further assessment based on the question, risk, and available evidence. This is a practice concern, not a claim about the prevalence of poor school FBAs.

Agree first, then answer

Plans can work without an experimental FA. Call et al. (2024) detected no statistically significant difference in FCT success between assessment groups in 57 young autistic children receiving expert-supported assessment and treatment. That is not proof of equivalent outcomes in all school settings.

Gresham et al. (2004) found that 52% of reviewed school-based intervention studies did not report linking FBA information to intervention. This does not establish that no FBA occurred or explain every null finding. Tier 1 supports may be a reasonable first response to mild or class-wide concerns; urgent assessment and applicable obligations should not wait for tier failure.

Why I wrote this kit, continued

What the evidence adds

Hurl et al. (2016) found that FBA-based interventions outperformed non-FBA-based interventions (effect size = 0.85). The separate 0.06 effect compared non-FBA-based intervention with no intervention. These findings do not establish a universal advantage of experimental FA over every other FBA method.

In Call et al. (2024), structured descriptive assessment and FA agreed exactly for 10 of 26 children in the FA group (38.5%). This is a study-specific correspondence result, not the accuracy of all FBAs. Assessment should guide prevention, teaching, reinforcement, and measured outcomes.

Experimental formats can be individualized

Mueller et al. (2011) summarized 90 FAs in public schools. Trial-based FA samples conditions in classroom routines (Bloom et al., 2011). Brief FA uses short sessions and is not automatically routine-embedded. Latency measures time to the first response. Precursor analysis uses validated earlier responses. These features can overlap with other experimental formats.

PFA is a broader assessment process; IISCA is its synthesized experimental analysis. Original session-based IISCA and performance-based IISCA differ. The first-response/HRE procedures summarized here describe a performance-based variant. Differentiation supports the synthesized package, not each component's independent necessity (Hanley et al., 2014; Jessel et al., 2024).

Risk, competence, and next steps

No format guarantees safety. Document individualized risks and safeguards, stop criteria, assent/withdrawal indicators, and competent supervision (Deochand et al., 2020). Not all severe behavior has a reliably identifiable, functionally equivalent precursor. A severe event does not by itself prove assessor incompetence.

Select an appropriate case, not automatically the hardest student. Train implementers, demonstrate competency, check fidelity, and bring outcome data. This kit is a practice aid for supervised teams, not certification to conduct an FA independently.

I don't have a magical quick answer, but I have a process.

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Supplement: procedures, data workflows, and checklist (pages 25-29)

How to use this kit

This kit contains five experimental FA formats, printable datasheets, and graph pages. It supports individualized assessment planned and supervised by a competent behavior analyst.

Using the kit

1. Start with records, interviews, observation, student/family input, and classroom ecology. Define the behavior, the assessment question, and the evidence supporting or conflicting with the hypothesis.
2. Decide whether existing evidence is sufficient to guide a plan. If uncertainty matters, choose the least risky assessment likely to answer the question. Formats can overlap.
3. Specify the individualized protocol, measurement, condition-specific consequences, transition rules, stop criteria, and no-response coding. The summaries here do not replace original methods.
4. Print the matching datasheet and graph page. Graph promptly and review differentiation, fidelity, and safety events. Do not force a function conclusion from ambiguous data.
5. Link the evidence to prevention, skills, reinforcement, and a response plan. Measure behavior, participation, replacement skills, and implementation fidelity; revise as needed.

Safety first: before any experimental FA

A competent behavior analyst designs and supervises the analysis. Implementers must demonstrate procedural competence, with ongoing fidelity checks. Complete an individualized risk assessment and arrange appropriate staffing, materials, and a de-escalation plan.

Obtain applicable informed consent and authorization, and define assent/withdrawal indicators. Write stop criteria for injury risk, escalation, distress, and withdrawal. Honor safety stops immediately and document them separately from programmed segment transitions.

Latency, precursor, trial-based, and synthesized formats may reduce exposure in appropriate cases, but none guarantees safety. Do not substitute a precursor without sufficient evidence of its relation to the severe target.

Keep student records confidential under applicable privacy requirements and district policy. Use student IDs or codes on shared materials. This kit is not a substitute for training, supervision, or clinical judgment.

Session-based (analog) FA: task analysis

- 1 Confirm the assessment question, competent supervision, individualized risks, safeguards, consent, assent/withdrawal indicators, and stop criteria.
- 2 Operationally define the target response class; set session duration and measurement. Compare rates if session lengths vary.
- 3 Prepare the selected conditions, trained implementers, data collection, setting, and materials. Do not automatically test every possible function.
- 4 Play/control: provide the planned leisure and attention, with no demands; follow the specified control contingency.
- 5 Attention: arrange the planned attention restriction; deliver the programmed attention consequence contingent on the target.
- 6 Escape/demand: arrange the planned instructional demand; deliver the programmed break or demand removal on the target.
- 7 Ignore or alone, only if indicated: arrange the specified nonsocial condition with individualized safeguards; select based on risk.
- 8 Tangible, if indicated: arrange restricted access; deliver the programmed item access contingent on the target.
- 9 Run the selected experimental design with fidelity checks. Honor safety stops and record deviations separately.
- 10 Graph the selected measure by condition. Look for differentiated effects replicated across sessions.
- 11 If results are ambiguous, reassess condition design, measurement, fidelity, and context; extend or modify only as justified.
- 12 Link supported function(s) to the BIP. Document feasibility, uncertainty, and measured intervention outcomes.

Primary citation: Iwata et al. (1994, reprint of 1982); Saini et al. (2020)

Datasheet: page 11

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Full references: pages 22-23

Synthesized FA (IISCA): task analysis

- 1 Use an open-ended interview and relevant observation to identify evocative contexts, preferences, and potential reinforcer combinations.
- 2 Identify the selected IISCA variant. The original session-based and performance-based procedures are different.
- 3 Define targets and validated precursors, measurement, condition-specific transitions, safety stops, and assent/withdrawal indicators.
- 4 Prepare the synthesized reinforcer package and test events. The remaining steps summarize a performance-based variant.
- 5 Control: establish happy, relaxed, engaged (HRE) participation with planned reinforcers available and evocative events absent.
- 6 Test: arrange the interview-informed combined evocative events specified in the individualized protocol.
- 7 At the defined response criterion, restore the programmed synthesized reinforcers and transition according to the selected protocol.
- 8 Replicate control/test comparisons as specified. Honor withdrawal and safety stops; low exposure is not a safety guarantee.
- 9 Record target and precursor responses separately, condition durations, engagement, fidelity, and safety events.
- 10 Differentiation supports the synthesized contingency as a package. It does not show that every component is independently necessary.
- 11 Use the tested reinforcer package to inform functional communication, tolerance/cooperation teaching, and the school BIP.
- 12 If ambiguous or unsafe, revise the assessment with competent supervision. Do not assume that tightening precursor definitions resolves all risk.

Primary citation: Hanley et al. (2014); Rajaraman et al. (2022); Jessel et al. (2024)

Datasheet: page 12

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Trial-based FA: task analysis

- 1 Identify hypothesized functions and classroom routines that allow the selected test and control conditions.
- 2 Train implementers to competency. Specify segment durations, measurement, fidelity checks, and an individualized safety plan.
- 3 Use appropriate routine opportunities. Arrange the protocol conditions without unnecessary classroom disruption.
- 4 Control: arrange the specified reinforcer availability and absence of the test establishing operation. Record occurrence/non-occurrence.
- 5 If responding occurs in control, record it and follow the protocol's segment-transition rules. Do not automatically discard the trial or skip test.
- 6 Test: arrange the specified establishing operation and start the segment timing according to the selected protocol.
- 7 On test responding, deliver the condition-specific programmed consequence and follow the specified segment-transition rules.
- 8 If no response occurs, record non-occurrence at the segment limit. Record interruptions and safety stops separately.
- 9 Replicate comparisons across relevant routines and functions. Retain control data and identify invalid or interrupted segments.
- 10 Graph percent occurrence separately for test and control using the number of valid completed segments as each denominator.
- 11 Interpret replicated differentiation with fidelity and context data. Ambiguous results require review, not a forced function label.
- 12 Build a routine-specific BIP from supported evidence and monitor its outcomes. Original Bloom procedures used control-test-control segments.

Primary citation: Bloom et al. (2011); use the complete selected protocol

Datasheet: page 13

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Full references: pages 22-23

Latency-based FA: task analysis

- 1 Determine whether time to first response can answer the question with acceptable risk. Document safeguards and de-escalation arrangements.
- 2 Define the target, maximum session duration, no-response coding, and safety/withdrawal criteria.
- 3 Select relevant conditions and explicitly specify the programmed consequence for each; latency is a measurement feature, not one universal contingency.
- 4 Arrange each condition's antecedents and establishing operation exactly as specified.
- 5 Start timing at the defined condition onset. Record interruptions or deviations.
- 6 Respond to non-target behavior only as required by the protocol or documented safety/withdrawal rules.
- 7 At the first target response, stop timing, record latency, deliver the condition-specific programmed consequence, and end per protocol.
- 8 If no response occurs by the cap, record non-occurrence and the elapsed cap. It is a censored observation, not an actual response at that time.
- 9 Replicate comparisons across conditions under the selected experimental design. Do not exceed the individualized risk limits.
- 10 Graph latency with no-response/capped observations clearly distinguished. Do not code them as zero.
- 11 Replicated shorter test latencies relative to control may support a functional relation; similar latencies require assessment review.
- 12 Use supported findings to guide the BIP and outcomes. Consider other measurement or format features if the question remains unresolved.

Primary citation: Thomason-Sassi et al. (2011)

Datasheet: page 14

Blank graph: page 20

Full references: pages 22-23

Precursor FA: task analysis

- 1 Identify the severe target and candidate earlier, lower-intensity responses using descriptive data and stakeholder input.
- 2 Evaluate the precursor-to-target relation. Temporal precedence alone does not establish the same maintaining function.
- 3 Define the selected precursor and the evidence supporting substitution. Write safeguards for breakthrough severe events.
- 4 Specify test/control conditions and the condition-specific programmed consequence for the precursor.
- 5 Optional ACT notes are a separate team practice tool, not a required part of the Smith and Churchill (2002) procedure.
- 6 Arrange the selected test condition, measurement, duration, and experimental design under competent supervision.
- 7 Deliver the programmed consequence for the defined precursor. Do not wait for severe behavior to deliver it.
- 8 Run the matched control condition according to its specified antecedents and consequences.
- 9 Record precursors, severe targets, duration, fidelity, safety stops, and withdrawal separately.
- 10 Graph precursor responding by condition. Review severe events as clinically important safety data, not merely integrity errors.
- 11 Infer implications for severe behavior only when precursor/target linkage is adequately supported. Do not substitute when evidence is weak.
- 12 Link results to the BIP and monitor both precursor and severe behavior. Reassess when the relation or treatment outcomes change.

Primary citation: Smith and Churchill (2002); precursor substitution requires adequate evidence

Datasheet: page 15

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Standard (Analog) FA: Data Sheet

Continuous tally during fixed-length sessions (e.g., 5 or 10 min). Enter totals into Graphing Sheet → Analog FA tab.

Student name / ID: _____ Date: _____

BCBA / observer: _____ Session length (min): _____

Target behavior (operational definition): _____ Setting / materials: _____

How to use

- Mark the condition for each session. Tally every instance of the target during the session.
- Write the session total in the Total column. Graph responses per minute = Total ÷ session minutes.
- Alternate conditions (Attention, Demand/Escape, Play/Control, Tangible, Alone if used).

Session log

Date	Sess #	Start	Condition (circle one)	Behavior tally (hash marks)	Total
			A D P T L		
			A D P T L		
			A D P T L		
			A D P T L		
			A D P T L		
			A D P T L		
			A D P T L		
			A D P T L		
			A D P T L		

Conditions: Attention | Demand (Escape) | Play (Control) | Tangible | Alone (if indicated). Print one sheet per student / day as needed.

Condition key (circle in Condition column): A = Attention D = Demand/Escape P = Play T = Tangible L = Alone

Practical Functional Assessment (PFA / IISCA): Data Sheet

Synthesized control/test data. Identify the IISCA variant and measurement before use.
Original: Hanley et al. (2014); performance-based: Jessel et al. (2024).

Student name / ID: _____ Date: _____

BCBA / observer: _____ Phase length (min): _____

Target / precursor definitions: _____
Synthesized EO (from interview): _____

Synthesized reinforcers (HRE): _____ Who implements: _____

How to use

- Control: provide the programmed reinforcers; no evocative events.
- Test: arrange the synthesized EO; deliver the programmed package and transition per selected variant. Record targets and precursors separately; honor safety stops.
- Tally targets and precursors separately. Do not wait for dangerous escalation.

Session log

Date	Sess #	Phase (C/T)	Start	End	Target tally	Precursor tally	Notes
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					

C = HRE control; T = test; EO = establishing operation. Use variant-specific transitions.
Compare rates only when meaningful for the selected measurement and format.

Trial-Based FA: Data Sheet

Binary occurrence in Control then Test (about 1 to 2 min each). Bloom et al. (2011). Graphing Sheet → Trial-based FA tab.

Student name / ID: _____ Date: _____

BCBA / observer: _____ Target behavior: _____

Classroom / activity context: _____ Trial length (min): _____

How to use

- Run Control segment first, then Test for the same condition (Attention, Demand, or Tangible).
- Record control responding and follow the protocol's segment-transition rules; document safety stops.
- Mark Occurred / Did not for each segment. Later graph % of trials with occurrence by condition.

Trial log

Time	Trial #	Activity	Cond (A/D/T)	Control	Test	Stop?
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N
			A D T	☐ Occ ☐ No	☐ Occ ☐ No	Y N

A = Attention; D = Demand; T = Tangible. Stop = documented safety stop, not control responding.

Latency-Based FA: Data Sheet

Latency to first response. Thomason-Sassi et al. (2011). Deliver the condition-specific programmed consequence and end per protocol. Use the Latency FA tab.

Student name / ID: _____ Date: _____

BCBA / observer: _____ Target behavior: _____

Max session time (e.g., 5:00): _____ No-response rule (circle): blank / enter max seconds: _____

How to use

- Start timing at condition onset. At the target, record latency and deliver the condition-specific programmed consequence; end per protocol. Mark non-occurrence separately.
- No response by cap: record non-occurrence and elapsed cap; indicate censoring in the graph.
- Shorter latency means earlier onset. Do not code a capped trial as a response at the cap.

Session log

Date	Sess #	Condition (circle)	Occurred?	Time to first (min:sec)	Seconds	Notes
		A D P T L	Y N			
		A D P T L	Y N			
		A D P T L	Y N			
		A D P T L	Y N			
		A D P T L	Y N			
		A D P T L	Y N			
		A D P T L	Y N			
		A D P T L	Y N			

Condition: Attention | Demand | Play (control) | Tangible | Alone. Occurred: Y / N. Graph seconds (lower = faster onset).

Condition key: A = Attention D = Demand P = Play (control) T = Tangible L = Alone

Precursor FA: Data Sheet

Deliver the condition-specific programmed consequence at a validated precursor. Smith and Churchill (2002). Optional ACT notes are separate team practice. Use the Precursor FA tab.

Student name / ID: _____ Date: _____

BCBA / observer: _____ Session length (min): _____

Severe target (do not evoke repeatedly): _____ Precursor definition (validated earlier response): _____

EO / demand used in Test: _____ Programmed consequence: _____

How to use

- Control: EO absent / reinforcers available as designed for this analysis.
- Test: arrange the EO. At the defined precursor, deliver the condition-specific programmed consequence. Do not wait for the severe target.
- Record precursors and severe events separately. ACT notes are not part of the 2002 method.

Session log

Date	Sess #	Phase (C/T)	Precursor tally	Target tally	Away note	Toward note	Notes
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					
		C T					

C = Control; T = Test; EO = establishing operation. Record severe events and safety stops. Precursor substitution requires adequate linkage evidence; no format guarantees safety.

The FA graphing template

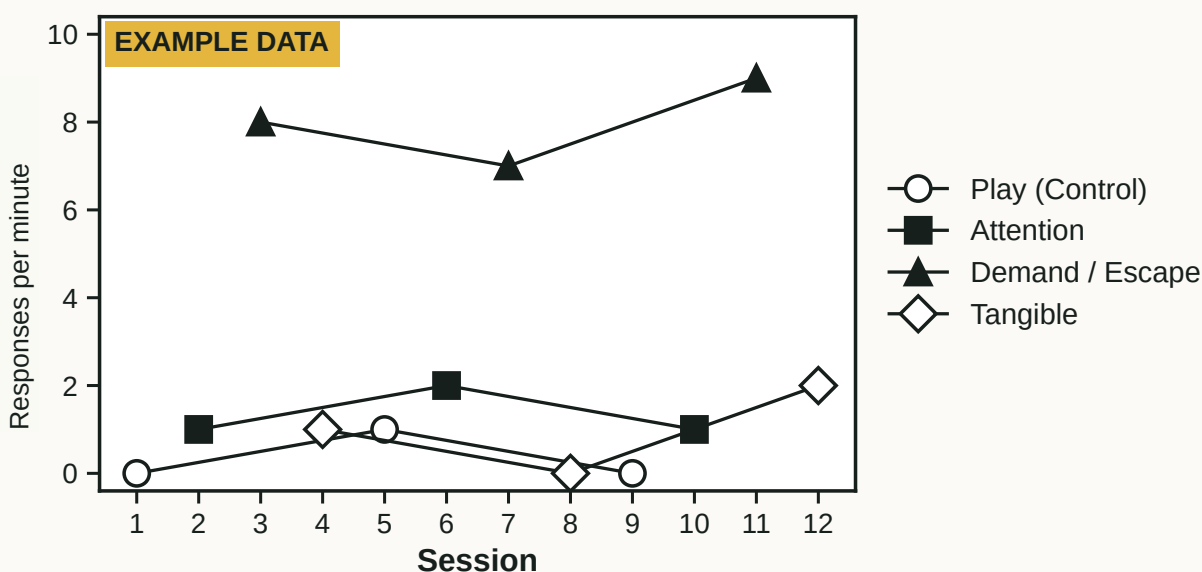
Hand-graphing works fine, and Part 3 gives you a blank graph page for each format. If you'd rather type, the **School FA Graphing Template** is a Google Sheet that draws the graph for you. **A copy link comes with your signup** at behaviorschool.com/FA. Make a copy for each student, and start on the Instructions tab.

The flow: collect on the datasheet → type the numbers into the white cells of the matching tab → the chart builds itself. Gray columns calculate on their own; blank rows are skipped, never plotted as zero.

Tab	What you type → what the chart shows
Analog FA	Session, condition, count, minutes → responses per minute by condition
Synthesized (IISCA)	Session, Control/Test, count, minutes → target per minute, Control vs Test
Trial-based FA	Block, condition, Y/N in control and test → % of trials per block
Latency FA	Session, condition, latency; mark no response at cap as censored
Precursor FA	Session, Control/Test, precursor count, minutes → precursors per minute
EXAMPLE: Analog FA	Made-up demo data with a filled chart

Use a different color and marker for each condition; connect points within each condition only. For latency, distinguish capped no-response observations from actual responses. Document the cap and censoring rule. Missing data are not zero.

Example graph: Standard (analog) FA, multielement



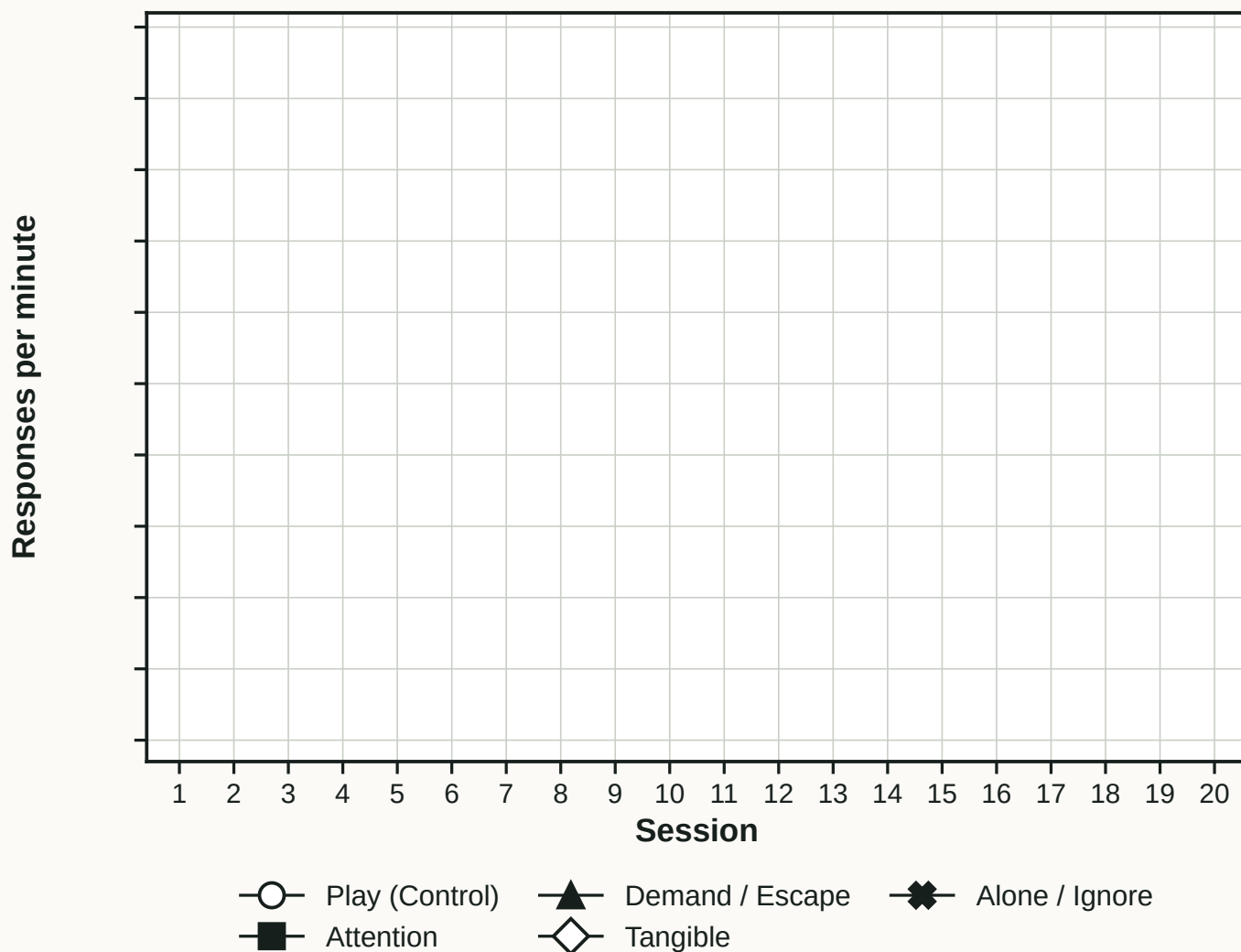
Example data. Made-up demo values from the template, not a real student. Here responding is highest in Demand and stays low in Play (control), which would support an escape function. Markers differ by condition, and lines connect points within each condition only.

Standard (analog) FA graph

Student ID / code: _____ Target behavior: _____

Dates: _____ Session / phase length: _____

Responses per minute by session, one marker shape per condition. Plot each session above its session number; connect points within a condition only. Write your y-axis scale on the tick marks.



Notes / decision:

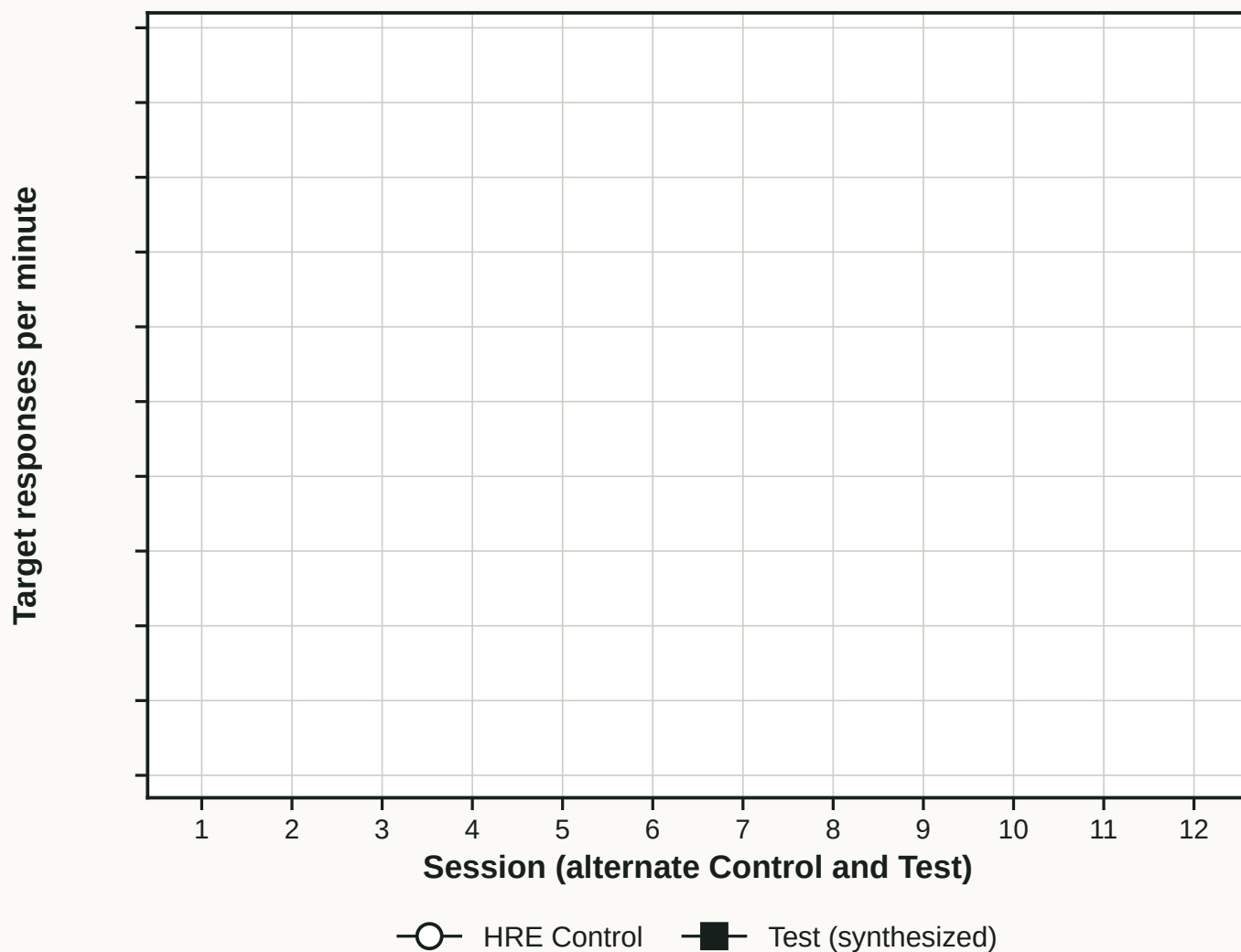
Data from the datasheet on page 11, Sheet tab: Analog FA in the School FA Graphing Template (Google Sheet)

PFA / IISCA graph

Student ID / code: _____ Target behavior: _____

Dates: _____ Session / phase length: _____

Select measurement for the IISCA variant. If graphing rate, record duration and compare Control with Test; connect points within condition. Differentiation supports the contingency package.



Notes / decision:

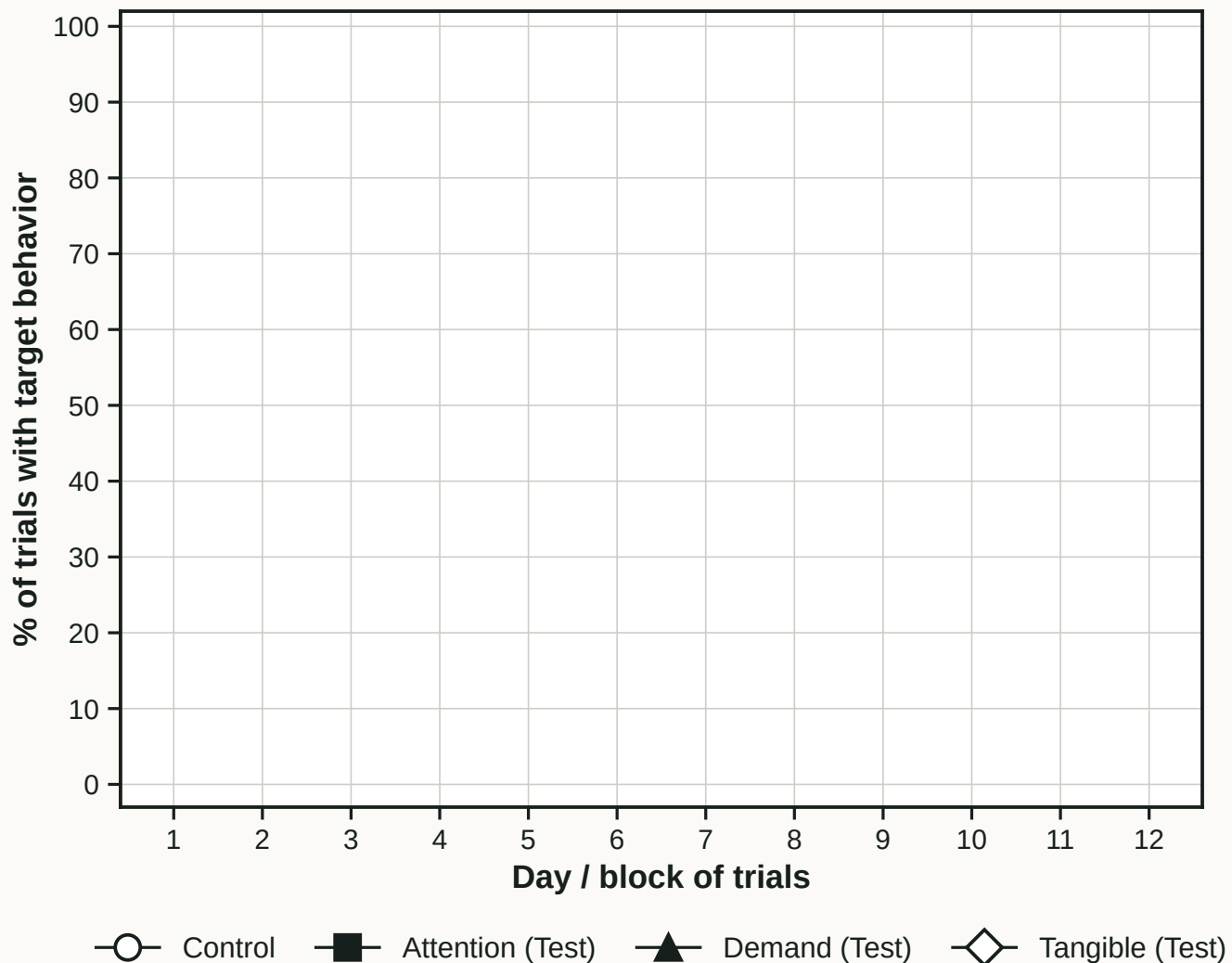
Data from the datasheet on page 12, Sheet tab: Synthesized (IISCA) in the School FA Graphing Template (Google Sheet)

Trial-based FA graph

Student ID / code: _____ Target behavior: _____

Dates: _____ Session / phase length: _____

Percent of trials with the target behavior, by day or block. Control vs each Test condition; % = trials with occurrence ÷ trials run × 100.



Notes / decision:

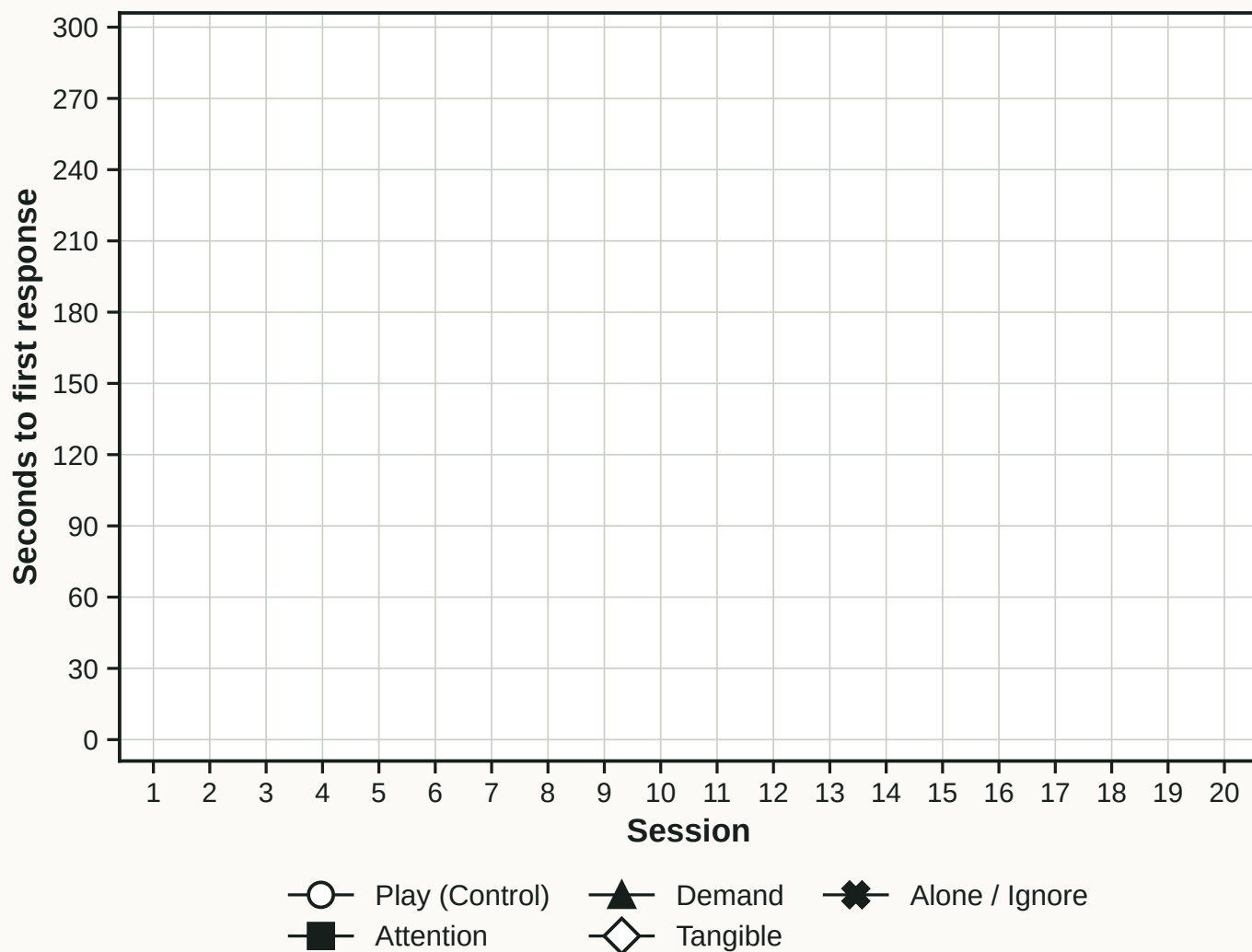
Data from the datasheet on page 13, Sheet tab: Trial-based FA in the School FA Graphing Template (Google Sheet)

Latency-based FA graph

Student ID / code: _____ Target behavior: _____

Dates: _____ Session / phase length: _____

Seconds to first response by condition; 300 s is an example cap. Mark no-response observations as censored, not actual responses at the cap. Do not plot missing observations as zero.



Notes / decision:

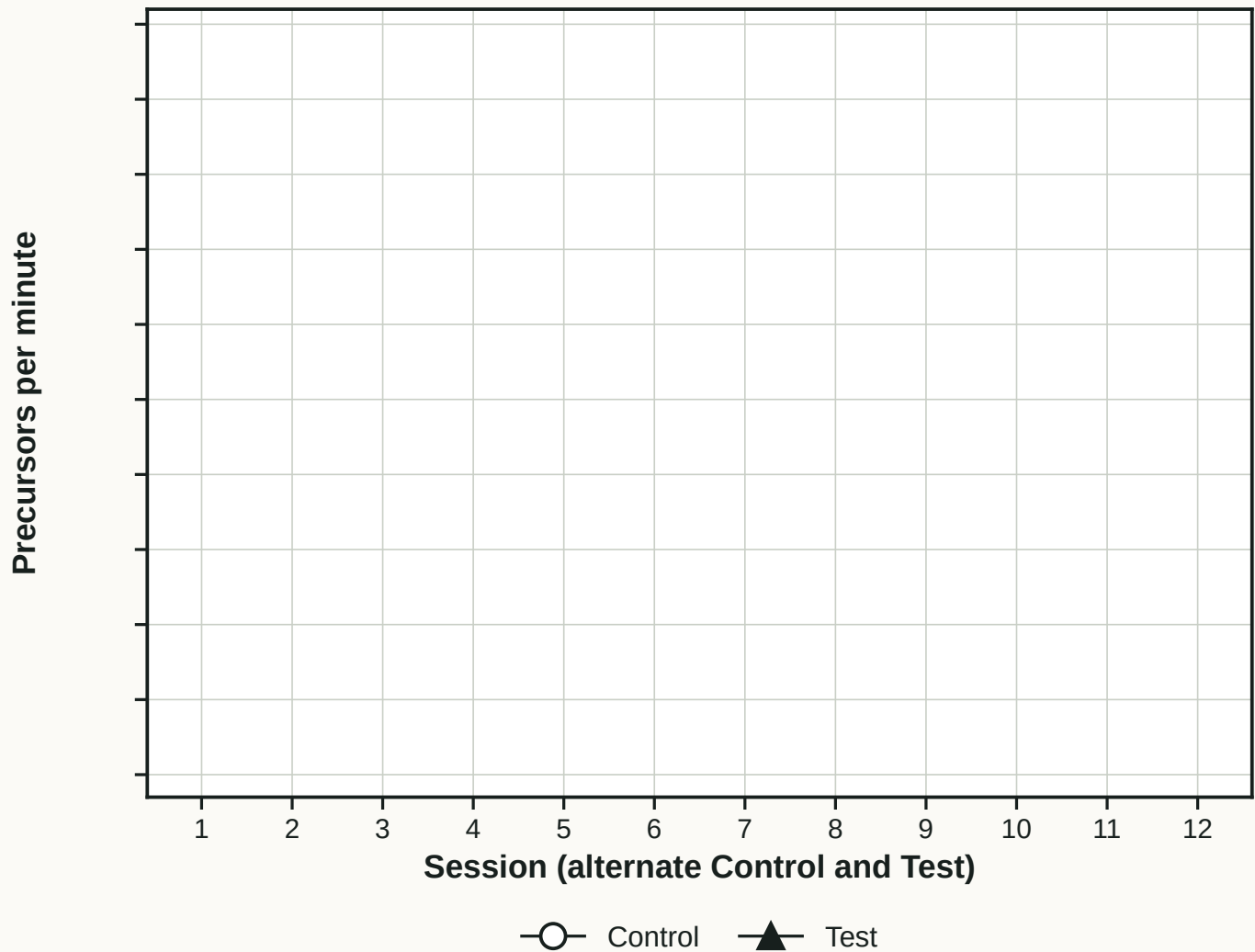
Data from the datasheet on page 14, Sheet tab: Latency FA in the School FA Graphing Template (Google Sheet)

Precursor FA graph

Student ID / code: _____ Target behavior: _____

Dates: _____ Session / phase length: _____

Precursors per minute, Control vs Test. Record severe events separately and review their clinical and safety significance. They do not necessarily indicate assessor error. Set the y-axis scale.



Notes / decision:

Data from the datasheet on page 15, Sheet tab: Precursor FA in the School FA Graphing Template (Google Sheet)

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<https://doi.org/10.1007/s10864-005-0960-5>

Free published implementation resources

Open-ended interview, IISCA design forms, and related materials are available from the Practical Functional Assessment site: practicalfunctionalassessment.com/implementation-materials. Choose materials for the specific variant and obtain competent supervision.

The course page does not provide a verified publication date, so n.d. is used. Journal references use issue publication years; historical publisher digitization dates are not treated as original publication dates.

Assess, don't guess.



Thanks for doing this work, and for bringing a process to the table instead of a guess.

If you want help building this into a system across your whole caseload, that's what the **School BCBA Systems Transformation Program** is for:

behaviorschool.com/transformation-program

More from me: robspain.com

I don't have a magical quick answer, but I have a process.

Brief and extended FA guidance

Before either format

These summaries supplement the task analyses on pages 6-10. They are not complete clinical protocols or independent authorization to conduct FA. Select an appropriate case, obtain required consent, define assent/withdrawal and safety stops, and use competent supervision. Demonstrate staff competency and check fidelity.

Brief session-based FA

1. Define the target and the question left unresolved by the broader FBA. Select the indicated test and a matched control.
2. Specify a brief duration, programmed consequences, measurement, design, and stop criteria. A short session does not make the procedure routine-embedded.
3. Run the planned comparisons. Record count and actual duration, fidelity, context, and safety events.
4. Compare rates when durations differ. Look for replicated condition effects, not a single high point.
5. If evidence is insufficient, review the design and consider justified replications or an individualized extension. Use supported findings to guide a BIP and measure its outcomes.

When more analysis is needed

Review ambiguous or inconsistent results, fidelity problems, possible untested variables, and poor treatment response. Correct interpretable design or measurement problems before extending exposure. More analysis may mean additional replications, a revised condition, another experimental design, or specialist input. It does not automatically mean testing every condition or moving to a supposedly more formal format.

Condition scripts and setup

Use page 6 for the session-based setup and condition summaries. Specify antecedents, the establishing operation, control arrangement, condition-specific programmed consequence, duration, and stop rules. Latency and precursor features can overlap with other formats. Continue reviewing classroom ecology throughout assessment.

Sources and forms

Saini et al. (2020), <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaba.583>; Iwata et al. (1994, reprint of 1982), <https://doi.org/10.1901/jaba.1994.27-197>. Full references: pages 22-23. Datasheet: page 11. Blank graph: page 17.

Data workflows: brief and trial-based FA

Brief FA

Plan: define the response and choose the test/control comparison from the strongest assessment lead. Use the brief guidance on page 25 and session-based task analysis on page 6.

Collect: record count, actual session duration, condition, context, fidelity, and stops.

Read: compare test with control across replications. Counts are comparable only when duration and observation opportunities are comparable.

Use: link supported findings to prevention, teaching, and reinforcement in the BIP. If mixed, gather the evidence needed to resolve the question.

Trial-based FA

Plan: identify natural routines for the selected control/test segments. Train staff and specify the protocol, including segment-transition rules. See page 8.

Collect: score occurrence/non-occurrence separately in control and test. Record routine, condition, interruptions, fidelity, and safety stops. Control responding is data, not an automatic reason to discard a trial.

Read: compare percentages within the same hypothesized function and relevant routine across repeated blocks. Short exposure or classroom interruptions can obscure a relation.

Use: build routine-specific prevention, communication teaching, and reinforcement. Follow the complete chosen protocol rather than substituting generic transition rules.

Calculations and coding

Rate = responses divided by observed minutes.

Percent occurrence = completed valid segments with a response divided by all valid completed segments of that condition, multiplied by 100.

Keep control and test denominators separate. Document interrupted, invalid, stopped, and missing segments. A blank cell is not a zero. A safety stop is not the same as control responding.

Sources and forms

Bloom et al. (2011), <https://doi.org/10.1901/jaba.2011.44-19>; Saini et al. (2020), <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaba.583>.

Forms: pages 11 and 13. Graphing instructions: page 16. Blank graphs: pages 17 and 19.

Data workflows: latency and precursor FA

Latency FA

Plan: define the target, conditions, timing onset, time cap, no-response coding, condition-specific consequences, and safety/withdrawal rules. See page 9.

Collect: start at defined condition onset. At the first target, record elapsed time, deliver the programmed consequence, and end per protocol. Document interruptions and stops.

Read: replicated shorter test latencies relative to control may support a functional relation. A capped no-response observation is censored, not an actual response at that time.

Use: base intervention on supported condition effects. Similar latencies or coding uncertainty require review, not a forced function label.

Precursor FA

Plan: define candidate earlier responses and evaluate the precursor-to-severe-target relation.

Temporal precedence alone does not establish functional equivalence. See page 10.

Collect: deliver the condition-specific programmed consequence at the validated precursor. Record precursor and severe events separately, along with duration, fidelity, and stops.

Read: differentiation supports the assessed precursor relation. Inferences about severe behavior need adequate linkage evidence.

Use: monitor both precursor and severe behavior during intervention. Reassess if linkage is weak or outcomes change. Not all cases have a usable precursor. Severe events do not automatically imply assessor error.

Timer and graph conventions

Convert minutes:seconds to seconds as 60 times minutes plus seconds. Record the planned cap separately from observed response latency. Distinguish actual responses, capped non-occurrence, safety stops, and missing records. Never silently code missing data as zero. For precursor rates, divide precursor count by observed minutes. Keep severe events visible in separate records.

Sources and forms

Thomason-Sassi et al. (2011), <https://doi.org/10.1901/jaba.2011.44-51>; Smith and Churchill (2002), <https://doi.org/10.1901/jaba.2002.35-125>. Forms: pages 14-15. Graphing instructions: page 16. Blank graphs: pages 20-21.

Data workflows: synthesized and extended FA

Synthesized FA / IISCA

Plan: use interview and observation to define the synthesized contingency, matched control, target/precursor definitions, and the selected IISCA variant. PFA is a broader assessment process. IISCA is an experimental tool within it. See page 7.

Collect: record targets, precursors, condition duration, engagement, assent/withdrawal, fidelity, and safety events separately. Original session-based IISCA and performance-based IISCA have different transitions and measurement requirements.

Read: differentiation supports the tested contingency as a package. It does not show that every component is independently necessary. A rate graph is not a substitute for a performance-based event timeline.

Use: connect assessment findings to an individualized communication and skill-teaching plan. Test component necessity separately if that question matters.

Extended session-based FA

Plan: identify the unresolved assessment question. Select relevant separated conditions and a matched control. Use the setup and condition summaries on page 6, with the extension guidance on page 25.

Collect: record the selected rate or interval measure, condition, actual duration, context, fidelity, and stops.

Read: seek replicated condition effects. Review undifferentiated results for design, measurement, and contextual problems. More sessions alone do not resolve every uncertainty.

Use: select supported BIP components and document feasibility and remaining uncertainty. Verify intervention effects with outcome data.

Graph interpretation across formats

Read the unit and condition labels before comparing points. Look for replicated separation, consistency, overlap, and alternative explanations. Graphs from the live deck are hypothetical demonstrations, not clinical participant outcomes. Count graphs assume comparable session durations. The latency demo does not specify whether its 300-second values are actual responses or capped non-occurrence, so verify coding before interpreting those points.

Sources and forms

Hanley et al. (2014), <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaba.106>; Jessel et al. (2024), <https://doi.org/10.1007/s40617-023-00792-2>; Saini et al. (2020), <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaba.583>. Full references: pages 22-23. Forms: pages 11-12. Blank graphs: pages 17-18.

School FBA process: take-home checklist

A proposed practice checklist

Use this checklist to organize an assessment and connect its evidence to intervention. It is not a validated scoring instrument, a fixed confidence threshold, or a substitute for applicable requirements. The sequence can be individualized. Urgent assessment and legal obligations must not wait for tier failure.

Before and during assessment

1. Referral and educational context: state the concern, question, relevant routines, history, and decision the team needs to make.
2. Student/family voice and dignity: document preferences, participation, consent, assent/withdrawal indicators, and safety safeguards.
3. Operational definitions and response class: define observable targets, measurement, and any proposed precursor linkage.
4. Classroom ecology: review instructional match, engagement, feedback, reinforcement, transitions, and setting events throughout assessment.
5. Indirect and descriptive evidence: document interviews, record review, direct observation, patterns, and limits. Distinguish correlation from experimental evidence.

From assessment to an evaluated plan

6. Further-assessment decision and risk screen: decide whether uncertainty justifies FA, which format answers the question, and what safeguards and competencies are needed.
7. Individualized FA plan, if used: specify design, conditions, programmed consequences, measurement, fidelity, transitions, and stop criteria.
8. Hypothesis and uncertainty: identify supported relations, competing explanations, and the evidence adequate for the next decision.
9. Function-based BIP linkage: name the assessment evidence behind each prevention, teaching, reinforcement, and response recommendation.
10. Implementation and revision: assign responsibilities, demonstrate competency, check fidelity, measure outcomes, and specify when to revisit the assessment or plan.

Supporting sources

Presenter-proposed synthesis, not a checklist reproduced from a single paper. Sources: Deochand et al. (2020), <https://doi.org/10.1007/s40617-020-00433-y>; Saini et al. (2020), <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaba.583>. FBA/BIP implementation background: Van Acker et al. (2005), <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10864-005-0960-5>. Full references: pages 22-23.